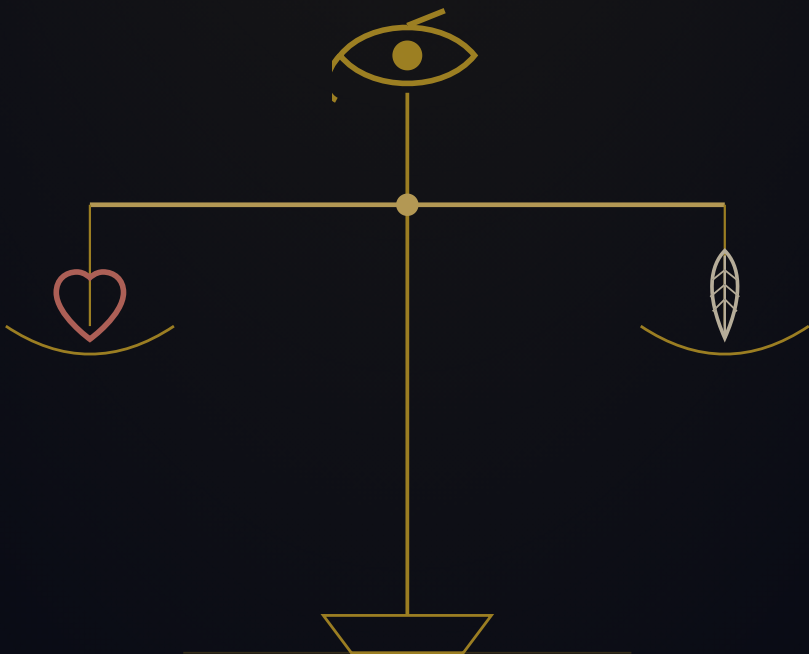


TANTRAYA'S GUIDE TO

THE DUAT

A traveller's guide to the Egyptian underworld, twelve hours of night, one
*border crossing that matters more than any other, and a very good reason to
bring your heart.*



THE WEIGHING OF THE HEART

BEST TIME TO VISIT	CURRENCY	LANGUAGE	VISA REQUIRED
Immediately after death	Offerings only	Egyptian, spoken with confidence	Yes, your heart

WELCOME TO THE DUAT

You're reading this guide because you're about to travel somewhere no return ticket exists for, or at least, none that looks like the one you came in on. The Duat is the realm the sun god Ra crosses every night between sunset and sunrise, and it's where you, the newly dead traveller, will spend twelve hours of night crossing though subjectively it may take considerably longer, since time works differently once your heart is the only thing still keeping a schedule.

This isn't a haunted house. It's a functioning country with borders, checkpoints, wildlife, and at least one crocodile-headed customs officer who will eat you if your paperwork is wrong. Think of it less as "the afterlife" and more as a long, dark river cruise with mandatory stops, each with its own regional customs and hazards.

The good news: people have made this crossing successfully for over four thousand years, and they left detailed notes, written on tomb walls, coffins, and a papyrus scroll that, we cannot stress this enough, you need to have brought with you. This guide collates that wisdom into something you can actually use.



BEFORE YOU GO

Documents you cannot travel without.



BOOK OF THE DEAD

Not sold at the border. Prepare and bury it with you in advance, ideally personalised with your name written directly into the spells, the same way a boarding pass with your name gets you further than one that says "Passenger."



YOUR HEART, UNDISTURBED

Weighed against a feather at customs. Mummification removes most organs but leaves the heart in place, because it's your only valid ID.



HEART SCARAB

Worn over the chest, inscribed with Spell 30B, which politely instructs your own heart not to testify against you. You are allowed to brief your own witness beforehand.



DJED PILLAR

For stability along the spine. Associated with Osiris's backbone and, by extension, endurance.



TYET KNOT

The Isis knot, generally in red stone, for protection along the road.



WEDJAT EYE

The Eye of Horus, for general wellbeing and safe passage through hostile terrain.

Shabti figurines. Small servant statues, ideally 365, plus 36 overseers, one for each day of the year. Should labour be demanded of you in the Field of Reeds, speak the activation spell and a shabti steps forward in your place. Essential for travellers who intend to spend eternity resting rather than farming, which is to say: all of them.



⌄ SYMBOLISM

GETTING THERE

Your journey begins at sunset, which is also every day Ra's own journey begins, so you'll have decent company on the road. The dead travel west, following the sun through the horizon and into the mountain that swallows the sky. Practically speaking, this means your tomb. The tomb is not your final resting place so much as it is departures.

You'll travel initially on foot, then by boat, joining the solar barque of Ra as it's towed through the twelve regions of the night by a crew of gods. Passage isn't guaranteed to just anyone, you're not a paying passenger so much as a soul who has proven, through correct ritual and correct knowledge, that you belong on it. This is why the spells later in this guide matter more than anything else you pack.



👁 LORE

THE HALL OF TWO TRUTHS

The checkpoint everyone talks about, and for good reason, it's the one you cannot bribe, charm, or argue your way through.



ANUBIS

Meets you at the door, escorts you to the scales. The friendliest official you'll encounter.



THOTH

Records the result. Precise, fair, entirely unmoved by flattery.



OSIRIS

Presides from his throne, flanked by Isis and Nephthys. The head of state here.



MA'AT

Goddess of truth and order, present as the feather itself. The standard you're measured against.



AMMIT

"The Devourer." Not a threat to be negotiated with, what happens if you fail the audit.

Your heart is placed on one pan of a golden scale. On the other sits the feather of Maat. If your heart is lighter, unweighed by unresolved wrongdoing, you pass. If it's heavier, Ammit eats it on the spot, and with your heart gone, you cease to exist in any afterlife at all. Worse than any punishment with a name: simply deletion.

Before the weighing, you recite the Negative Confession to the forty-two provincial assessors, not a list of virtues, but forty-two individual not-guilty pleas, each addressed to a different specialist judge.

1

I have not committed sin

2

I have not committed robbery with violence

3

I have not stolen

4

I have not slain man or woman

Traveller's tip. These forty-two statements are effectively a values audit for an entire civilisation, violence, theft, honesty, sexual conduct, religious respect, emotional harm, civic fairness. Spell 125 helps you make the declaration correctly, but a rehearsed lie in this hall does not work. Thoth is a scribe, not a fool, and Ammit is not persuaded by delivery.

If you pass, Thoth records the result and Horus presents you to Osiris, who welcomes you as maa-kheru, "true of voice." A stamped, valid passport for the rest of the Duat.



~ MYTH & SYMBOLISM

THE ITINERARY

THE TWELVE HOURS OF THE NIGHT

Per the Amduat, "That Which Is In the Underworld", the Duat divides into twelve regions, one for each hour of night. Ra's barque, and you with it, moves through all twelve without exception. This is the route.



THE GATES OF THE WEST

Where the sun sets and your journey formally begins. Baboon-headed deities greet the barque, howling, a hospitable welcome, not an alarm. Still lit by the last of the daylight.

I



THE WATERS OF WERNES

Fertile and watery, described in ancient sources as abundant and provisioned. Relative calm. A good hour to rest.

II



THE WATERS OF OSIRIS

The domain most closely tied to Osiris's own mythology. A reminder that you're walking a path a god walked first, and survived.

III



THE DESERT OF ROSETAU

Jagged, snake-filled, the domain of Sokar. The barque transforms into a serpent to navigate the sand. Real hazard begins here.

IV



THE CAVERN OF SOKAR

The deepest, most secretive hour. Ra's power and Osiris's body mystically unite here, regenerating both, the low point that is secretly the turning point.

V



UNION WITH THE BODY

The barque reaches its deepest point. Ra's ba reunites with his body, prefiguring the sunrise still hours away, the exact bottom of the arc.

VI



BATTLE WITH APOPHIS

Apophis attempts to drain the waters ahead and halt the sun entirely. Isis and Seth fight him off. The single most dangerous hour, stay close to the barque.

VII



GARMENTS AND VOICES

The dead are given fresh linen and the hour rings with the blessed calling to one another. Strange and almost festive after the previous crisis.

VIII



HOURL OF ROWERS

Twelve gods row the barque forward, joined by fire-spitting cobra guardians. Steady, guarded progress, endurance rather than heroics.

IX



RESTORING THE EYE

Healing and restoration, particularly of the wedjat, and special regenerative treatment for the drowned dead. A hospital-like atmosphere.

X



RENEWED TIME

The barque is towed by a rope of serpents; time itself regenerates. Uraeus goddesses spit fire to clear the final stretch. The destination is close.

XI



REBIRTH AT DAWN

The barque passes through the body of a giant serpent, entering at the tail and emerging rejuvenated at the mouth as the sun, and you are reborn at the eastern horizon.

XII

Alternative itineraries. Some travellers will instead find the Duat structured as the Book of Gates, the same journey divided into twelve heavily guarded gates rather than continuous regions, each requiring the guardian's name to pass. Same destination, different border crossings. If your tomb was inscribed with Book of Gates material, use gate names instead of hour names, but expect the same overall arc: descent, danger, deep midnight crisis, rebirth.



BEINGS YOU'LL MEET

A quick-reference guide to who's who, showing up unable to identify an official is its own kind of danger.



FIRST CONTACT

ANUBIS

Jackal-headed god of embalming, escorts the dead to judgment. Broadly protective and unlikely to deceive you.



THE SCRIBE

THOTH

Ibis-headed god of writing and wisdom. Precise record-keeper of the entire trial.



HEAD OF STATE

OSIRIS

Lord of the dead, later ruler of the Field of Reeds. Not approached casually.



PROTECTORS

ISIS & NEPHTHYS

Osiris's sister-wives, who fought for his resurrection in life. Generally sympathetic to travellers.



ENFORCEMENT

AMMIT

"Eater of the Dead." Not evil exactly, an automated enforcement mechanism with teeth. Nothing personal.



ANTAGONIST

APOPHIS

The great chaos-serpent, most dangerous at Hour VII. You don't fight him, that's the gods' job. Stay close to the barque.



THE STANDARD

MA'AT

Goddess of truth and balance, present as the feather itself. Not conversed with, measured against.



TRANSPORT

AKEN, THE FERRYMAN

Runs the waterways. Requires the correct names and password before he'll carry you across see below.

↓ PRACTICE

GETTING PAST THE FERRYMAN

Several points along the Duat require crossing water by ferry, and the ferryman will not simply take you across because you asked. Egyptian funerary texts preserve entire interrogation scripts in which he demands the name of every single part of his boat before letting a soul aboard, the mast, the rudder, the plank, the rope, each one individually.

Practical advice. This is not a memory test designed to fail you, it confirms you actually belong here, the same way detailed questions at customs test consistency rather than trying to catch you out for fun. Travellers whose funerary texts included the correct names for the ferry's parts pass without incident. You cannot improvise this section.



↩ PRACTICE

A TRAVELLER’S PHRASEBOOK

The Book of the Dead is, functionally, a phrasebook for exactly this trip. You won't need all roughly 190 known spells, but the following come up constantly.

SPELL 1

GOING FORTH BY DAY

Recited at burial itself. Sets the whole journey in motion correctly.

SPELL 6

THE SHABTI SPELL

Activates your servant figures should labour be demanded of you. Reusable throughout the trip.

SPELL 17

ORIENTATION

A long foundational spell establishing your identity with the major gods and the cosmology of the Duat itself. Less a single phrase, more your general briefing.

SPELL 30B

ADDRESS TO THE HEART

Instructs your own heart not to testify against you. Inscribed onto the heart scarab, not just spoken it needs to travel with you physically.

SPELL 125

THE NEGATIVE CONFESSION

The single most important spell in the whole collection. This is the one you cannot afford to fumble.

SPELL 144/149

PASSING THE GATES

For the seven, or in some versions twenty-one, gates and mounds, each guarded by a being who must be addressed correctly by name.

SPELL 148

PROVISIONING

Ensures food offerings reach you and don't spoil or go to someone else.

Dying again within the underworld was considered a real and final danger, distinct from ordinary bodily death. Worth having on hand for the entire trip.

Etiquette note. Spells work through correct recitation, not sincerity of tone. Closer to using correct legal phrasing in a formal document than to prayer. Precision matters more than emotion here.



♀ PRACTICE

PRACTICAL TIPS FOR TRAVELLERS

- 0 **Do not travel without your name.** Your name (ren) is part of your soul, alongside your ka and ba. If it's forgotten by the living or erased from your monuments, part of you genuinely ceases to exist.
- 0 **Offerings are not optional extras.** Food, drink, and incense left at your tomb are your actual sustenance. A well-provisioned traveller has an easier crossing.
- 0 Hesitation reads as guilt. Confident, correct recitation matters enormously, especially at the Hall of Two Truths. This is not a place to improvise.
- 0 **Stay close to official transport.** The solar barque and guided routes exist because the Duat off-route is considerably more dangerous.
- 0 **Bring companions if you can.** Isis, Nephthys, Horus, and other gods actively assist travellers who have made correct preparation. You are not meant to do this alone.



YOUR FINAL DESTINATION: THE FIELD OF REEDS

Assuming a successful crossing, you arrive at Aaru, a lush, idealised mirror of the best of Egypt itself: fertile fields, grain grown to giant proportions, waterways, and eternal daylight. This is your actual destination, not the Duat itself, which is properly understood as transit rather than terminus.

Here you'll farm your own plot of land, though, thanks to the shabti you brought, you're not actually required to do the labour yourself. You'll be reunited with family who made the crossing before you. You'll live under the rule of Osiris, in a place ancient texts describe with the specific, practical detail of people who valued a good harvest above almost anything else.

This is not an eternity of abstract bliss. It's an eternity of a very good life, the kind the living in Egypt worked their entire mortal lives to be able to afford.



AT A GLANCE

QUICK REFERENCE

STAGE	WHAT IT IS	KEY FIGURES	WHAT YOU NEED
DEPARTURE	Death and burial	Anubis	Mummification, Book of the Dead, amulets
HALL OF TWO TRUTHS	Judgment	Anubis, Thoth, Osiris, the 42 Assessors, Ammit, Ma'at	The 42 Negative Confessions, Spell 125
HOURS I-VI	Descent into deepest night	Sokar, Osiris	Endurance, correct spells
HOURL VII	Battle with chaos	Apophis, Isis, Seth	Stay near the barque
HOURS VIII-XI	Ascent and restoration	Rowing gods, Uraeus goddesses	Patience
Hour XII Rebirth at dawn Ra reborn, you've made it			
FERRY CROSSINGS	Water passages	Aken, the ferryman	Names of every part of his boat
FINAL DESTINATION	Aaru, the Field of Reeds	Osiris, family, ancestors	Shabti figures, and nothing else



Safe travels. Speak clearly. Know your assessors by name.

And whatever you do, don't forget your heart.